

The Pipes at Dawn

Scotland's battle pipers from Loos to Normandy: what really happened, what the enemy said, and which parts are only legend.



1915 • 1940 • 1942 • 1943 • 1944

Large-print edition

Maps, the pipers' own words, the roll of named pipers, the tunes they played, and a record check on every famous claim.

The famous claims, one by one

THE STORY	WHAT THE RECORD SHOWS	VERDICT
German soldiers called kilted Scots "Die Damen aus der Hölle", the Ladies from Hell.	The phrase was in British newspapers by Christmas 1914, quoting Scottish soldiers who said the Germans used it. Searches of wartime German sources have not found it. German letters talk about the kilts, but call all British troops simply <i>Engländer</i> .	LEGEND made in Britain
German veterans passed the name, and the fear, on to their sons.	No source for this has been found.	UNPROVEN
Piper Daniel Laidlaw played his company out of the trench at Loos and won the Victoria Cross.	Citation in the <i>London Gazette</i> , 18 November 1915. See page 5.	CONFIRMED
After the First World War, the Army banned pipers from playing men into battle.	Piper losses were very heavy. But no written order has ever been found, and a 1920 history says piping in action was left to volunteers.	UNPROVEN
Pipers played the 51st Highland Division into the attack at El Alamein.	Battalion records from the night of 23 October 1942 say the leading companies went forward with their pipers playing.	CONFIRMED
A wounded piper kept playing until he died.	Piper Duncan McIntyre of the 5th Black Watch is said to have played on after being hit. He died on 25 October 1942. The detail comes from one regimental source.	PARTLY TRUE

Bill Millin's D-Day



Schematic map; positions approximate. The route inland is about 9 km (6 miles); the beach to Pegasus Bridge is about 6 km in a straight line.

- 1 Queen Red, La Brèche, about 08:40.** Millin plays *Hielan' Laddie* in the surf, then *The Road to the Isles* along the water's edge.
- 2 Inland via St-Aubin-d'Arquenay.** The brigade marches to join the airborne troops holding the bridges.
- 3 Bénouville, the canal bridge (Pegasus Bridge).** Just after 13:00, playing *Blue Bonnets over the Border*.
- 4 The Orne bridge (Horsa Bridge), 400 m on.** Lovat's order: keep going and don't stop.

The piper steps off



Commandos of 1st Special Service Brigade land from their landing craft on Queen Red beach, La Brèche. Photograph by Captain J. L. Evans, No. 5 Army Film and Photographic Unit. Imperial War Museum B 5103. UK Crown copyright, now public domain.

Look closely

The blurred man in the foreground, with the drone of his bagpipes sticking up over his right shoulder, is Piper Bill Millin, about to follow the commandos into the water. The museum's caption places Lord Lovat in the water to the right of the column. Behind them: tanks, landing craft and the seafront villas of La Brèche.